

May 3 dawned a brilliant, crisp day, and by the time the sun was rising above the trees at Hazel Grove, this key terrain was in Confederate hands. Southern artillery swarmed the open ground, dominating the clearings of Fairview and Chancellorsville, and opened a murderous fire on Union infantry and artillery holding those positions. Waves of Southern infantry assaulted hastily prepared Federal brigades posted in the woods to the north and south of Fairview. Some of the most vicious fighting of the war occurred before Hooker ordered the abandonment of first Fairview, and then Chancellorsville.

Despite having two corps standing idly by that could have crashed into Stuart's northern flank, Hooker chose to retreat. Nearly all his subordinates agreed that Chancellorsville was one of the greatest Northern lost opportunities of the war. Against all odds, Lee had scored a tactical victory, inflicting 17,000 casualties on the enemy while suffering 13,000 of his own—though among these was the irreplaceable Jackson.